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Poster

Auditing Not-Knowing:

The Universal Ignorance Audit and the Epistemology of an AI-Assisted Research Pipeline

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1 Introduction

Ignorance is usually handled as an absence: list the gaps, then fill them. This work treats not-knowing as a **structure** with parts that can be named: load-bearing assumptions (**scaffolds**), models mistaken for the world (**map–territory errors**), felt anomalies (**wobbles**), defended zones (**protected ignorance**) and productive capacities (**actionable** and **relational** ignorance).

It builds on agnotology [3], specified ignorance [2], ignorance as a driver of science [1], judgment under uncertainty [4], forecaster calibration [5] and intellectual humility [6]. AI-assisted research makes fluent text cheap and moves the bottleneck to evaluation: a pipeline must be able to say what it does not know about its own outputs.

Objectives

1. Present the **Universal Ignorance Audit (UIA)** [7], a fifteen-question, five-phase instrument for making not-knowing legible in any domain.
2. Read one documented case through it: a published paper from the author's AI-assisted pipeline [8], judged machine-generated by two AI-assisted forensic analyses that made errors of their own.
3. Propose governance principles and state testable claims.

2 Methodology

Development (one day, human–AI dialogue)

6	12	12	13	**Meta**	15
seed questions	meta-questions (AI)	sharper questions (human): power, body, taboo	v2.0, five phases	audit of the audit	final form

Administration protocol

R1 Name the target X before questioning.
R2 Answer every question; if one seems inapplicable, say why and stretch to find its relevance.
R3 Write the answers down.
R4 Do not resolve during Phases 1–4.
R5 Allow silence after Question 14.
R6 Question 15's answer seeds the next pass.

Case analysis and implementation

The findings of two separate AI-assisted forensic analyses (assessments of whether the paper was machine-generated) were re-coded **post hoc, by the author**, into UIA categories; the analyses were then read with the same categories. Software: **`ignorance-audit` 0.1.0** (Python) checks R1 and R2, chains passes from Q15 (R6), runs the audit with any text model and scores the 2028 error-category claim; 20/20 tests pass (19 Oct 2026).

PHASE 1 — Surface the Structure
1. **Scaffold detection** — *What hidden assumptions hold this up?*
2. **Map–territory** — *Where might the map be taken for the territory?*
3. **Wobble probe** — *Where is the tension, the thing that does not fit?*

PHASE 2 — Stress-Test the Frame
4. **Inversion** — *What if the opposite were true?*
5. **Falsifiability** — *What would a world look like in which this was false?*
6. **Invariants** — *Change the base, origin or frame: what stays the same?*

PHASE 3 — Multiply Perspectives
7. **Radical shift** — *How would this look to a radically different observer?*
8. **Externalised ignorance** — *Who knows what I do not, and what is my biggest blind spot to them?*

PHASE 4 — Uncover the Hidden Forces
9. **Power** — *Who benefits from this framing? Who is silenced?*
10. **Protected ignorance** — *What is the most dangerous question I could ask?*
11. **Somatic, tacit** — *What does this ignorance feel like, and what does the feeling know?*

PHASE 5 — Act
12. **Wilful** — *What do I know but pretend not to?*
13. **Actionable** — *What can I do with this uncertainty now?*
14. **Relational** — *What does the unknown want from me?*
15. **Meta** — *What question am I not asking?*

Recursion: the answer to Q15 seeds the next audit pass (protocol rule R6).

Figure 1. The Universal Ignorance Audit, ordered from surface structure to protected depth and ending in action (wording abridged).

3 Case and interpretation

3.1 The case, re-coded in UIA categories

UIA category	What the forensic analyses reported about the paper [8]
Q1 Scaffold	Inline meta-tags labelling the text's own modes; citation keys that resolve to nothing: the production process left visible.
Q2 Map–territory	Decoder power set to ≈ 0 from $O(\log_p N)$ complexity and called a "conservative upper bound"; zero is a lower bound. Complexity stood in for dissipation.
Q3 Wobble	Landauer's bound at 300 K vs 10 mK: erasure floors conflated with room-temperature coherence; no thermal-noise mechanism.
Q1–2 The auditors	Both analyses called the organisation fabricated; one called the author's name invented. Both claims are false: *unrecognised* was read as *non-existent*, a known unknown that called for checking.
Read twice	Its admission that its metric lacked external validation was read as a symptom of generation; the audit reads it as a partial scaffold breach: process showing through, so data.

Table 1. Forensic findings, re-coded post hoc by the author into UIA categories. Illustrative, not a test: the errors were found without the UIA.

3.2 The pipeline's response (self-reported)

- **Disclosure** of AI involvement, with corrections, instead of deletion.
- A **generation-specific gate** for energy-budget errors, unresolvable citations, scaffold overload and self-referential metrics.
- **Adversarial validation** over self-review.
- **Auditing the auditors** with Q1, Q2 and Q10 [8].

3.3 Proposal: three layers of epistemic legibility

Provenance — A truthful, checkable account of how each output was made. **FAILS AS** scaffold

Ignorance — The programme can state the structure of its not-knowing. **FAILS AS** map–territory error

Auditor — Every verifier is itself auditable. **FAILS AS** protected ignorance

Figure 2. Legibility = what a pipeline can show about how, and how well, it knows. Three layers proposed from the case, each with the UIA category for its typical failure.

3.4 The meta-audit (AI-drafted) bounds the method

- Assumes ignorance is mainly generative: risky in clinical or safety-critical use.
- Listing a blind spot is not seeing it.
- Analytic and extractive; underweights receptive, non-verbal knowing.
- Favours articulate, time-rich users. Sibling questions followed; several entered the final form.

4 Registered claims and limits

Due	Claim, and what would falsify it (UIA §8)	Status
2027	An audit surfaces an assumption a programme's practitioners had not named. Fails if audits only restate known ones.	Pending
2028	On AI-assisted outputs, the audit catches an error category standard checks miss. Fails if it adds nothing beyond existing gates.	Pending
2028	Another researcher, in another domain, finds it net-positive. Fails if inert or harmful.	Pending

Limitations

- One case, coded post hoc by a party to it: illustrative, not validating.
- The instrument is unvalidated and auditor-dependent by design.
- Not culture-free; no substitute for domain expertise.
- Claims sit in a preprint, not a registry, in the register format the analyses flagged as an AI marker.

5 Conclusion

We propose that, in an AI-assisted pipeline, **epistemic legibility is the core governance problem**, and that its failures are recursive: the analyses that caught the paper's scaffolds made unverified claims of their own. Verifiers need auditing too.

Audit before asserting — Audit major claims before publishing.
Disclose, don't conceal — Concealment makes quality an integrity issue.
Provenance as a gate — "How was this produced?" is a required field.
Gate for generation — Test fluent models' own failure modes.
Invite adversaries — Publish disconfirmation conditions.
Audit the auditors — Every verification layer is another map.

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Declarations

Conflict of interest. The author wrote the analysed paper, commissioned the analyses, directs QNFO and licenses the software (commercial use by agreement). The case is a first-person account. No external funding.

Use of AI. An LLM assistant (model not recorded) extracted the meta-questions, drafted v2.0 and the meta-audit; the forensic analyses were AI-assisted; the library was built in the author's AI-assisted pipeline; Claude (Anthropic, Opus 5.5) drafted, fact-checked and laid out this poster. The author is responsible for all content.

Method paper · Synthesis · Code